bedrock of a new rural constituency that the party created for itself in the Hindi heartland between 2014 and 2019. It grew deep roots here in new areas outside urban centres, which powered its re-election and electoral ascendance. Over half the Lok Sabha seats in the region are rural: 127 of 225. UP has roughly the same ratio of rural seats: forty-six of eighty.

No Longer a City-only Party

The most striking illustration of the BJP's rural growth comes from vote shares. In the Hindi heartland's 127 rural constituencies, the BJP managed to win over 40 per cent vote share in only 16.5 per cent seats in 2009. In 2014, it more than tripled that number to 57.4 per cent of rural seats and upped it further to a whopping 74.8 per cent in 2019. This rising rural depth of the party gave it a rural hegemony, way above its nearest competitors. In multipolar contests within India's first-past-the-post election system where dozens of candidates contest from individual seats, a 40 per cent threshold on vote share is a premier performance benchmark for political parties, indicating a decisive presence: especially so in contests with three or more major players.[1] Now, about half the states in the Hindi heartland are multiparty polities. (The exceptions are Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Himachal Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Uttarakhand, which are two-party polities, with the Congress in direct competition with the BJP.) In 2009, the Congress was ahead of the BJP in these 127 rural constituencies, winning over 40 per cent vote share in 23.6 per cent of the seats. Yet, that number collapsed to 8.6 per cent in 2014 and 11.8 per cent in 2019. In other words, the Congress shrank in rural seats, becoming over six times smaller than the BJP in the decade between 2009 and 2019 (Figures 2.1, 2.4).

This pattern becomes even more telling when we narrow-focus on UP. Of the forty-six rural Lok Sabha seats, the BJP won over 40 per cent vote share in just 6.5 per cent seats in 2009. Yet, in 2014, it won such ascendance in over half these seats, and in as many as 82.6 per cent seats in 2019. When a party wins more than 40 per cent vote share in over 80 per cent of rural seats in a state